



FOR MORE
STORIES

Zverev, Andreeva break Grand barrier

Alexander Zverev fulfilled a decade-long promise while Meera Andreeva produced a fairytale run to win their **maiden Grand Slam titles** at Roland Garros.

Paul Fein

Chaos on clay. How else to describe this wild and wacky Roland Garros? High seeds were battered by inspired underdogs, roasted in record Parisian heat, and confounded by blustery winds. And then, in the men's draw, the stars finally aligned for Alexander Zverev. No longer would the 29-year-old German be defined, even disparaged, as 'the greatest player never to win a Grand Slam title'. In his fourth Major final and second at Roland Garros, Zverev outlasted Flavio Cobolli 6-1, 4-6, 6-4, 6-7(5), 6-1.

A plague of injuries had decimated the men's field. Defending champion Carlos Alcaraz and four young rising stars — Lorenzo Musetti, Arthur Fils, Holger Rune and Jack Draper — withdrew before the tournament. Sinner thus became the prohibitive favourite, while Zverev was seeded No. 2 and the ageless Novak Djokovic No. 3.

Even more important than redeeming his heartbreaking Roland Garros final loss to Alcaraz a year ago, Sinner yearned for tennis immortality: a rare career Grand Slam. In the Open Era, only Rod Laver, Andre Agassi, Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal, Djokovic and Alcaraz have achieved it.

But just as Sinner's team feared and Martina Navratilova predicted, the Italian's surprisingly fragile body betrayed him in the record-breaking heat.

In the second round against No. 56 Juan

Manuel Cerundolo, Sinner was on the brink of victory. Leading 6-3, 6-2, 5-1, the slender Italian appeared to cramp in both legs and could barely move. The Argentine left-hander then won 18 straight points, and neither the tennis gods nor a highly controversial 10-minute medical timeout at 5-4 in the air-conditioned clubhouse could save Sinner.

To his tactical credit, the poised, poker-faced Cerundolo extended rallies with a variety of shots to keep the valiant but debilitated Sinner moving around. The Italian poured water over his head and used a hand fan during changeovers but inexplicably, didn't leave the court for a desperately needed break after the fourth set. With Sinner looking like a dead man walking, Cerundolo won 18 of the last 20 games for a 3-6, 2-6, 7-5, 6-1, 6-1 victory.

"One of the biggest upsets we've ever seen in tennis — or in sport," exclaimed *TNT* analyst Sam Querrey.

Could Zverev capitalise?

That was the big question.

Going into the 2026 Roland Garros third round, Zverev had to be heartened that only one former Grand Slam champion was left in the draw. The bad news was that it was Djokovic, and his exceptional skills have not eroded, as his five-set win over Sinner showed in this year's Australian Open semifinal.

But the GOAT faced a prodigy in a